

TIOBE INDEX MARCH 2026: HOW 20+ SEARCH ENGINES RANK THE WORLD'S PROGRAMMING LANGUAGES

Python leads at 21.25% but posts the largest year-over-year decline among the top 5, while C surges to second and Go drops from 7th to 16th.

PYTHON HOLDS #1 AT 21.25% BUT C SURGES TO #2

Mar 2025	Mar 2024	Change	Programming Language	Rating	Change
1	1		 Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	▲	 C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	▼	 C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	▼	 Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5		 C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6		 JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	▲	 Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8		 SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	▲	 R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10		 Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	▲	 Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12		 Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	▼	 Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14		 Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15		 MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	▼	 Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17		 Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	▼	 PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	▼	 Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	▲	 Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

- **Python Dominates:** Holds the top position at 21.25%, more than double the rating of second-place C.
- **Largest Decline:** Despite its lead, Python experienced a year-over-year drop of **-2.59%** points.
- **C's Resurgence:** C gained **+2.02%** points, climbing from 4th to 2nd place.
- **High Concentration:** The top 4 languages (Python, C, C++, and Java) collectively account for nearly 49% of the total index.

THE BIGGEST RANK SHIFTS OF 2026

BIGGEST GAINERS

- **Perl:** Jumps 13 spots (24th → 11th, +1.05%)
- **R:** Climbs 7 spots (16th → 9th, +0.94%)
- **Swift:** Rises 6 spots (26th → 20th, +0.44%)

Legacy languages show surprising resilience in data and infrastructure.

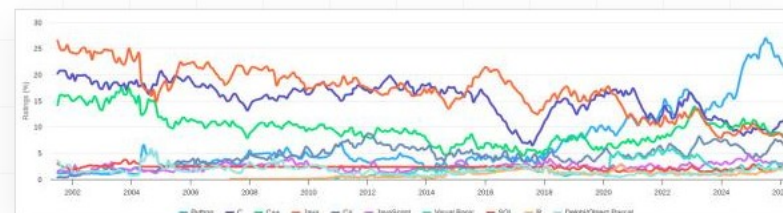
NOTABLE DROPS

- **Go:** Drops 9 spots (7th → 16th)
Largest absolute drop (-1.49%)
- **C++:** Drops 1 spot (2nd → 3rd, -2.90%)
- **Java:** Drops 1 spot (3rd → 4th, -2.37%)

Modern favorites face new headwinds as ecosystems shift.

FROM LISP AT #2 IN 1986 TO PYTHON AT #1 IN 2026: HISTORICAL SHIFTS

- **Four Decades of Stability:** C is the *only* language that has remained in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning 40 years.
- **Python's Climb:** Python was unranked before 1991, entered the top 30 in 2001, and took 25 years to reach #1.
- **Java's Trajectory:** Dominated the index from roughly 2005 to 2018, peaking in the 25%+ range before declining.



PYTHON WINS LANGUAGE OF THE YEAR 6 TIMES

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2017	C
2016	Go
2015	Java
2014	JavaScript
2013	Transact-SQL
2012	Objective-C
2011	Objective-C
2010	Python
2009	Go
2008	C
2007	Python
2006	Ruby
2005	Java
2004	PHP
2003	C++

Python's Record:

Won the award 6 times (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024), more than any other language.

C#'s Recent Momentum:

Won twice recently (2023, 2025), driven by steady growth in the .NET ecosystem.

Go's Reversal:

Won in 2016, but is currently experiencing the sharpest decline in the top 20.

THE TOP 4 LANGUAGES HOLD 49% OF THE INDEX: WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR TECH STACK

The top 4 languages hold 49% of the index, creating both stability and concentration risk.

1. THE PYTHON PARADOX

While utterly dominant at 21.25%, Python's massive year-over-year decline (-2.59%) suggests its peak market share may have passed.

2. LEGACY REVIVAL

C, Perl, Fortran, and R are surging. Established infrastructure and data analysis stacks are holding strong against newer alternatives.

3. SYSTEMS SHIFT

Go's sharp fall alongside Rust's steady gains suggests shifting preferences in modern systems programming.